

Listen Up – Seeking Asylum: Sara's story

What am I? Why am I? Who am I? How am I different?

Hi! I'm Sara. I'm 14 ½ years old. I'm from Kosovo, which is somewhere around here – oh, I'm not even on the map – anyway, somewhere here. I live with my mum, in London. I like London a lot. I'm getting to know it pretty well because I've moved, like, three times in different places, so in the weekends I like to hang around with my friends, listen to the music, I love listening to the music, all the time.

Approximately 34,000 people applied for asylum in the UK in 2004.

Many of them are school age children.

We used to stop during night-time. There was another woman with her child in the lorry – keep on driving for three days. The driver said some place safer (?). Actually my race, like Ashkali race, are really (in) danger in there.

Sara and her mother Miletcha fled Kosovo in November 2004, hidden in the back of a lorry. They are waiting to hear if they can stay in the UK. Sara comes from a persecuted ethnic minority. Following accusations of collaboration with the Serbs, the family suffered several attacks. Sara's father was killed.

I'm worried that what's going to happen, and I'm worried that my mum's going to be so stressed and she's really not well and ..shy.. I've always been the strong one, since I was little.

Seeking asylum

July 2005, Croydon, South London

(Radio) OK, this is where I sleep, my mum – (man:) Your mum sleeps here. Yes. This is where I watch TV. There's where I put my stuff and just – my stuff. That's what I'm reading right now *Up all night* . Yes, it's good, it's about a woman who's getting divorced and has got two children and her everyday life.

Whilst waiting for a school place Sara taught herself English by watching TV and reading magazines. She attended Westwood Language College Croydon for a few weeks at the end of last term. My teachers told me, like, tell your mum that she should be proud and she shouldn't worry, because I talked to some of them. And they were really impressed with my English as well, and I'm learning French and Spanish-I'm really good, and they're like, oh, it's a gift, you're really good at languages and stuff. I would like to be a lawyer, when I'm older – like, you know, to go to uni and be a lawyer – people's rights – I like the idea of this because I can help people and stuff.

4.14